escalation of hostilities to land-based targets, fearing the impact of retaliatory responses on Chinese soil. Severe criticism of Xi Jinping's decision not to launch ballistic missile attacks against US air bases in Japan discounted his focus on achieving victory solely on the immediate battlefield, as opposed to risking a larger US retaliation for bombing targets in an allied country. This initial hesitancy on both sides led to a gradual widening of conflict, but each escalation was linked directly to the specific action that preceded it. This kept the scale of the conflict limited in its early days, which in turn shaped the operational response (see a fuller discussion of limited war aims in the fifth point, below).

Fourth, the actual course of combat operations largely followed the insights of geopolitical analysts Halford Mackinder and Nicholas John Spykman.[42] Both Mackinder and Spykman stressed the crucial importance of the "rimlands": the littoral and adjacent maritime space, which Spykman called the "marginal seas." The rimlands are the vital areas that must be controlled, given their importance in populations, industrial production, and access to the continental interior and its resources. However, to control the rimlands, the inner seas must be dominated by one power. In other words, it is in the marginal or inner seas that the struggle for mastery takes place, between what Mackinder called the "inner crescent" of the littoral mainland and the "outer crescent" of the peninsular littoral (in this case, formed by Japan, Taiwan, the Philippines, and other nations of Southeast Asia).

US and Chinese combat operations focused on winning the war in the marginal seas, along the littorals, and not on expanding combat either to the continent (in the case of the United States) or to third countries like Japan (in the case of China). Naval forces were concentrated at key choke points or along vital sea lines of communication, such as the Miyako and Jeju Straits, which formed the hinges between the East and South China Seas. Taiwan also played a central geopolitical role here, and its declaration of neutrality was a major strategic gain for China. Similarly, the Battles of the Batanes, Ryukyus, and Santiago Island all underscored the importance of the littorals and strategic transit points.